

TEACHER LESSON PLAN

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Voice, Body, Story

Grades 5–8 · Theater

GRADES 5–8 | 45 MINUTES | THEATER ARTS

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

What students will understand

Students will explore storytelling, voice, and embodied performance through the lens of the Harlem Renaissance oral tradition — the spoken word, the blues shout, the preacher's cadence. They will develop and perform a short monologue, scene, or spoken word piece rooted in a Harlem Renaissance character or theme, and reflect on how performance creates empathy and historical understanding that written text alone cannot.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **National Arts TH:Cr1.1.5–8** — Identify physical, vocal, and emotional choices that heighten the impact of drama and theatre work
- **National Arts TH:Pr4.1.5–8** — Identify, analyze, and apply cultural and historical information to support a character interpretation
- **National Arts TH:Re9.1.5–8** — Examine how the context of a drama communicates the perspectives of a community or culture

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Character cards — one per student or pair (on handouts)
- Optional: audio of a Harlem Renaissance monologue or spoken word for model — recordings of Paul Robeson, Langston Hughes reading his own work, or a scene from a Zora Neale Hurston play
- Open space for performance — desks cleared if possible; alternatively, students remain seated for in-class reading performances

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

The body remembers

"Before we talk about the Harlem Renaissance, I want you to do something. Stand up. Take up as much space as possible — arms wide, feet apart, chin up. Hold it for 10 seconds. Now make yourself as small as possible — shoulders in, head down. Hold it. Now stana normally and notice: which posture felt more like you? Which felt like a choice? The performers of the Harlem Renaissance made a choice to take up space — physically, artistically, politically. Today we're going to explore what that means through performance."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · 10 MINUTES

The oral tradition

The Harlem Renaissance had a rich oral performance tradition: **blues shouters** (Bessie Smith, Ma Rainey) who used the voice as an instrument of testimony; **preacher rhetoric** (Adam Clayton Powell Sr. at Abyssinian Baptist Church) using call-and-response with congregations; street-corner oratory (Marcus Garvey); **spoken word and poetry readings** in Harlem salons and speakeasies; **theatrical performance** at venues like the Lafayette Theater.

"Zora Neale Hurston — folklorist, novelist, playwright — spent years collecting the stories, the sermons, the songs. She believed that how a community tells its stories is as important as the stories themselves. Today you're going to step into one of those stories."

ACTIVITY: CHARACTER WORK AND PERFORMANCE · 25 MINUTES

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

Receive a character card with background, situation, and sentence starters. Develop a 5–8 sentence first-person monologue. Practice with a partner, then share with the class (can be seated). Focus: speaking in first person and making one physical choice (gesture, posture).

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Choose a character from the provided list or create your own within the historical context. Write and perform a 60–90 second monologue. Must include one moment of silence (held pause) and one moment of vocal variety (volume, pace, or pitch change). Written reflection required.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Write and perform a 90–120 second monologue, scene for two voices, or spoken word piece. Must demonstrate: status awareness (how does your character hold power or lack of it?), subtext (what is the character not saying?), and one specific historical detail woven into the performance. Written dramaturgical note required.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit. **Option 2 — Virtual visit:**

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

CHARACTER SUGGESTIONS

Historical figures (simplified for drama purposes): Langston Hughes (poet, Harlem café, 1926); Bessie Smith (blues singer, backstage before a show); Aaron Douglas (painter, describing what he's working on); Zora Neale Hurston (folklorist, just returned from collecting stories in the South); Duke Ellington (musician, first night at the Cotton Club, 1927)

Fictional voices: A teenager who just arrived in Harlem from Georgia on the train; a woman hearing jazz for the first time at the Savoy; a letter-writer drafting a letter home from Harlem; a Southern newspaper editor watching his workforce leave northward; a school teacher in Harlem in 1925 on the first day of term

VOCAL TECHNIQUE NOTES

- **Pacing:** Slowing down = gravity, seriousness, emotional weight; speeding up = urgency, excitement, fear
- **Volume:** A whisper can be more powerful than a shout — it forces the audience to lean in
- **Pause:** The held pause is the most underused tool in student performance — silence after a significant line lets it land
- **Call-and-response:** The Harlem oral tradition is built on audience engagement — performers can look directly at the audience, ask rhetorical questions, pause for imagined response

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- What did you discover about your character that you didn't know before you performed them?
- How did your body affect your understanding of the historical context?
- What can performance communicate that written history cannot?

CROSS-CURRICULAR CONNECTIONS

- **ELA:** Monologue writing is first-person narrative with compressed dramatic arc — same craft skills as memoir and personal essay
- **Social Studies:** Stepping into a historical character builds perspective-taking — essential for historical empathy and analysis
- **Religion:** The preacher's prophetic voice (Amos, Isaiah) is a direct connection between the Harlem oral tradition and the biblical prophetic tradition
- **Music:** The blues shout, the jazz vocal style, and theatrical performance share rhythmic and tonal vocabulary